

THE CINEMATIC TOURIST

Rodanthi Tzanelli

The Cinematic Tourist

Explorations in globalization,
culture and resistance

Rodanthi Tzanelli

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The Cinematic Tourist

Recent years have seen a radical transformation of conventional tourist marketing and experience. The use of exotic locations in Hollywood films has allowed global audiences to enjoy distant places. Simultaneously, Hollywood screening of potential 'tourist paradises' has generated new tourist industries around the world. This book takes a closer look at this new phenomenon of 'cinematic tourism', combining theory with case studies drawn from four continents: America, Europe, Asia and Australasia.

The author explores audiences' perceptions of film and their covert relationship with tourist advertising campaigns, alongside the nature of newly-born tourist industries and the reaction of native populations and nation-states faced with the commodification of their histories, identities and environments.

Drawing on a wide range of disciplines, this fresh and original book will be of compelling interest for students and scholars of tourism, film theory, cultural studies, post-colonial studies, sociology and anthropology of culture, and political economy.

Rodanthi Tzanelli is Lecturer in Sociology at the University of Kent. Her main research interests include the sociology of nationalism, 'race' and ethnicity, the relationship of tourist and film industries and representations of deviancy. Her recent publications include articles in numerous esteemed journals including *Sociology*, *Tourist Studies*, *Mobilities*, *Ethnic and Racial Studies* and *Media, Culture and Society*.

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For Majid,
Gia panta

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Preface

It is the convention to say a few words about the way in which a published monograph has come to life, drawing attention to its academic significance. Often, however, this exercise becomes trapped in the academic vocabulary of seriousness – a performative act that, no doubt, eventually attains an objective status. As a result, scholars feel obliged to fill these first few pages with an account of the importance of their study complete with an apologia addressed to readers who invest time and energy to engage with it. I will and will not operate within these academic conventions. In reality, this book was born in a dim auditorium at Trafford Centre's cinema complex following the release of *Captain Corelli's Mandolin* in 2001. At the time, the film had caused pandemonium and rage in Greek communist circles for its association with what was considered an anticommunist novel by Louis de Bernières. All sorts of accusations were directed against Universal Pictures for encouraging this mindless commodification of Greek histories, and a war was waged against the *Corelli*-mania of global tourists. These reactions persuaded me and my friends to watch the film; later, they induced me to write the first article on it and its impact on self-narration on the island of Kefalonia, where the movie was filmed. Watching the film was, by all accounts, a rather banal experience – and mine was not much different from anyone else's. However, my academic engagement with it turned out to be more cumbersome than I expected: the Greek and foreign press, which was rife with articles on the *Corelli* phenomenon, had managed to communicate the less pleasant aspects of Hollywood's intrusion into the everyday life of island communities, an intrusion that was worsened by the international touristification of Kefalonia. These developments encouraged a reflexive process: however irrelevant my movie-watching experience might have seemed to be, it was not. As a consumer of a film that advertised Kefalonian nature and culture, I was implicated in the touristification of the island. This marked the moment at which I decided

to pursue a more detailed and culturally nuanced analysis of what I have termed the 'cinematic tourist' and 'cinematic tourism'.

This monograph, then, voices an aspiration to link the process of production – of novel, films, cultural difference and authenticity – to that of consumption – of films and the ideas they communicate, of actual filmed places. As I was to find out, practices of consumption can also reinforce structures of production: they can strengthen social inequalities in tourist industries, consolidate economic hierarchies of different nation-states in the international political arena and also result in the modification of filmed identities and cultures. Sociologists of consumption, political and moral economy, culture, media and cultural studies do not communicate well. The battle for territorial monopolies has taken a toll on a discipline so rich in subject matter, but so rigid in theoretical and political approaches. The idea of studying the whole ‘social life’ of commodities, to adapt Appadurai’s term, is still somehow inconceivable. In the case of the life trajectories of place and culture, sociologists tend to focus either on the economic structure of tourist industries or on the tourist experience. My aim in this monograph was to immortalize and analyse the whole production/consumption cycle (from the politics of filmmaking, to audience reception, to the generation and institution of tourism in filmed locations and the local, national and global reactions to the phenomenon). As happens with all ambitious studies, *The Cinematic Tourist* is, in places, incomplete or flimsy. This can be partially attributed to my attempt to do justice to all the important scholars who work in similar (Mike Crang, Sue Beeton, Tim Edensor, David Crouch and Ellen Strain to mention but a few) and other cognate areas (such as John Urry, Mimi Sheller, Don Slater and Scott Lash, again to mention very few), and to throw bridges between their work and that of more classical social theorists (such as Andrew Sayer and Michael Herzfeld). The interdisciplinarity of the book – it embraces historical studies, social theory, moral economy, critical and cultural geography, anthropology and media studies – may turn out to be an asset, but it has also complicated my theoretical approach. My empirical focus exposes the limitations of the study: tourism based on cinematic representations of place and culture is a phenomenon that has manifested its presence across the world – what with the *Harry Potter* craze of Japanese tourists photographing themselves in front of filmed locations in London, and the notorious *Da Vinci Code* court case that is on its way to generate tourist industries in the UK and Italy. In addition, the question of virtual tourism extends beyond that of cinematic tourism, on which I primarily focus. As artist and bestselling writer Euan Ferguson has intimated in a recent interview, today ‘you can Google up, say, “McMurdo Base” and “party”

and you'll find someone's posted digital party shots from Antarctica, and you're almost there' (*Observer Magazine* 2006). My attempt to connect cinematic tourism and Internet tourism may be interesting, but is also challenging. The fact that I did not operate within a recognized field certainly did not help, although the lack of disciplinary paradigms secured some intellectual freedom and creativity. As there is no such thing as 'cinematic tourist' studies, I have both the privilege and the terrifying responsibility to be one of the first authors who introduce it into sociology. Better informed work by more experienced academics may establish it in the discipline as an autonomous field.

1 The world of signs

Production as consumption/ consumption as production

Film and tourism

The Colosseum rests at the heart of collective European memory as a site associated with the greatness of Roman antiquity. Its international fame has compelled travellers equipped with travel guides and historical treatises to visit the monument and modern tourists to immortalize it with their cameras. At the turn of the new millennium a crisis began to brew amongst its glorified ruins: when the Italian state was repeatedly criticized for not providing the basic tourist facilities for its visitors – such as cafés, fast ticketing arrangements and museum options – the culture minister Giuliano Urbani supported its privatization (*Daily Telegraph* 2001). It seems however that the pledge to modernize the country's heritage industry has also been embraced by other Italian entrepreneurs, who have decided to exploit the monument's tourist potential in other ways. These are the modern 'gladiators' of Rome, who pose outside the Colosseum for tourists in their shiny costumes with baroque swords and other accessories from the realm of kitsch souvenir fantasy. The business of these 'warriors' picked up after the global success of *Gladiator* (2000), a Hollywood blockbuster directed by Ridley Scott and starring Russell Crowe as the gladiatorial hero who defeats the evil emperor Commodus (Joaquin Phoenix). Legions of tourists, who would normally spend time roaming the archaeological site and its museums, started visiting the monument just to be photographed with such colourful characters and take home evidence of their Roman experience.

Unfortunately, this enterprise acquired the infamy of an 'Italian job' when the costumed men were faced with numerous tourist allegations that they charge exorbitant prices for their services. The final blow was dealt when waves of complaints made their way into the press. Tourists reported that the gladiators' uniforms were cheap, their helmets plastic and 'they're not exactly Russell Crowe' (*BBC News* 2002a). As the saying

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goes, the customer is always right and it is fair to expect good value for money – as long as demands do not turn into an occupational hazard. Inevitably, accusations of shabbiness and lack of authenticity put immense pressure on these Italian men, forcing them to take extreme measures to respond to the challenge. In March 2002 the police arrested a gladiator who carried a real sword to look 'more authentic' to foreign crowds; traffic wardens repeatedly drove his colleagues off their patch to protect Rome's visitors from extortion; and, eventually, the city of Rome coerced these new businessmen to form a professional association and adopt a proper dress code that would appeal to their customers' tastes. Through these measures the authorities wanted to respond to comments that stereotyped the gladiators as 'just a group of men hanging around smoking', even if 'at a first glance [they] are very nice' (*ibid.*). This organized attack resulted in street conflicts, 'with tearful centurions claiming that they have families to feed' (*Daily Telegraph* 2003) and protesting that they have no money to buy fancy costumes for the benefit of foreigners. Such despair hardly fits the macho image of Crowe killing imperial villains.

The temptation to follow the gladiatorial episodes that ensued is great, but this would divert our attention from more important observations. These are: the tourists' urgency to secure the efficient performance of an act that reproduces a cinematic narrative which was never true to the historical record; the mobilization of the narrative by local entrepreneurs for economic reasons; the authorities' intervention in the controversy in order to regulate the provision of tourist services; and the city's overwhelming concern about the Italian cultural image abroad. To these obvious issues one could add some less obvious ones: what happened to those film viewers who never visited the Colosseum? How and what did they enjoy from the film? Did their desire to visit Rome lead them to learn more about its history? This book embarks on an investigation of these themes, exploring the impact that cinematic representations of place and culture have on the formation of the virtual tourist experience; the interplay between virtual and corporeal tourism following an exposure of audiences to cinematic representational apparatuses; the connections between cinematic production and the establishment of tourist industries on filmed locations; and the types of response that this phenomenon induces in host countries.

The title of the book encapsulates these themes, albeit in a rather condensed way. 'Cinematic tourism' and the 'cinematic tourist' are not uniform conceptual tools, but theoretical models internally differentiated by the moves and motions of travel through and after film, as well as the cinematic production of travel and tourism. To invoke Barthes (1993),

the cinematic tourist is a Hollywood myth, a construct that emerges out of a decontextualization of the actual touring experience. The Hollywood model of the tourist exists within cinematic texts, in the movies that we watch: it suggests ways of consuming places, enjoying and 'investing in' (for educational purposes) our holiday time. At the same time, touring through cinematic images produces a second type of tourist who uses the power of imagination to explore the world. This version of the tourist corresponds to the movie viewer, who 'reads' and consumes film. The surplus meaning of a film enables audiences to travel virtually, to experience the filmed locations at a distance: thus the impulse to visit these locations originates in the imaginary journey on the screen. A third version of the 'cinematic tourist' is created when a tourist industry is established in filmed locations, through the products that tourist industries offer when they exploit the film's potential to induce tourism. There is also a fourth type of cinematic tourist that completes the imagined journey of movie watchers. This is the tourist in the flesh, who visits places because they appeared in films, and whose experience of travel may be influenced by film and the attractions that the tourist industry has to offer. The interdependency of these types is not fixed: filmed locations are also visited by tourists who never watched movies and watching a movie will not necessarily result in visiting the filmed place. However, the bonds between these types of touring and the tourist are unmistakable and command analysis.

Tourism and the media: an overview

Tourism is an established subject area in the disciplines of sociology and anthropology, with research stretching back to the 1960s and 1970s or even earlier (see for example Norval 1936). Theoretically, scholars concentrated on the nature of tourism as a quintessentially modern phenomenon (MacCannell 1973), discussing tourist (Cohen 1974, 1979; Leiper 1979; Gottlieb 1982; Pearce 1982) and tourism (Boorstin 1962; Graburn 1977; Nash 1981) typologies, the relationship between hosts and tourists (MacCannell 1973; Hiller 1976; Pearce 1980) and the structure and cultural impact of tourism as a socioeconomic system (Greenwood 1977; Nash 1977). A synthesis and critical evaluation of some of these early perspectives that transformed the subject area has been John Urry's (1990) book *The Tourist Gaze*. Drawing on Foucault's concept of the gaze, Urry maintains that there are systematic ways of 'seeing' tourist destinations, which have roots in Western occulocentric practices, central to debates that envelop modernity. Urry already acknowledges the role visual culture has in the construction of the tourist

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experience and tourism as an organized system of leisure, a conviction that he carries forward in his more recent research (Urry 1995, 2000). It is precisely the centrality of the visual that this book aspires to analyse from a cinematic perspective.

The literature on cinematic tourism is surprisingly thin, given the growing importance of the phenomenon in the construction of the tourist experience and the representation of identity and culture. An interesting contextual analysis is provided by Fruehling Springwood (2002), who has argued that cinematic and televisual culture has equipped Japanese tourists with preconceptions of 'America' and a desire to visit specific locations. Fruehling Springwood stresses that the process of signification is culturally embedded and that it takes place prior to visiting the filmed location. An edited volume by Crouch, Jackson and Thompson (2005), with contributions from both media and tourist studies, places more emphasis on the role of imagination in tourism. In the introduction to the book the editors stress that 'the media are heavily involved in promoting an emotional disposition, coupled with imaginative and cognitive activity' (Crouch, Jackson and Thompson 2005: 1) that carries the potential to be converted into actual tourism. However, they also argue against conflating the mediation of tourism through television, newspaper and film images with the actual tourist experience, stressing that the former retains a utopian unboundedness that may be challenged by actual tourism, resulting in 'acute consumer dissatisfaction' (*ibid.*: 5). This argument has various ramifications, but here I wish to concentrate on two important ones (included in the volume) that I have integrated in my analysis. The first is developed by Fish (2005), who maintains that the process of 'viewing' is constituted by media producers through notions of touring. Televised images reflect tourism because they operate as escapist techniques, although their reception is not fixed. Fish implies that media producers generate ideal types of viewers, a notion which corresponds to the first type of cinematic tourist of my analysis.

The second dimension of the argument that I want to present comes from Edensor's (2005) research. Edensor focuses on the Hollywood blockbuster *Braveheart* to debate the ways media representations of history can affect understandings of national heritage. For Edensor film has an active role in the social construction of place and culture, not simply its marketization for tourists. Cinematic narratives are inscribed in historical landscapes, but the ways they are appropriated or contested by visitors/tourists may differ. The theme of manipulative creation of cinematic narratives also concerns Parsons (2000) who argues that aesthetic media images are able to manipulate myths of national identity powerfully, but

can also create new forms of popular identity. Like Edensor, she maintains that such representations of culture can be consumed by visitors at the destination. Edensor and Parsons highlight the shift from the first to the second, third and then fourth version of the cinematic tourist: from the film's ideal viewer to the real viewer and then the actual tourist. Other relevant studies do not stay within the ambit of 'cinematic tourism' as defined above, but explore more general connections between visual culture and tourism. For example, an edited volume by Crouch and Lübbren (2003) debates both how images inform tourist practices, form referential networks within them but are also constructed from actual tourist experience. The role of bodily presence, of 'corporeal bonding' with the new environment, is crucial in this experience (see also Crouch *et al.* 2001: 260–1). To make this observation applicable to the cinematic tourist thesis I want to suggest that film and tourism form a dynamic relationship of interaction which often has unpredictable outcomes. Unfortunately, little room is spared for an exploration of the actual tourist experience of filmed locations in this book; a few reflections are provided in Chapters 3 and 4.

Analytical differentiations of actual and virtual tourisms may be useful, but they bear the potential to obscure other important questions about the tourist experience as such. Following the trail of colonial studies, Strain (2003) identifies in tourism a romantic pursuit for authenticity that divorces the encounter with 'other' cultures from its political context. According to Strain, visual technologies have always been at the heart of these romantic pursuits, from the nascent steps of anthropology to the present endeavours of Internet, 'virtual' tourists. Cinematic technologies and the 'travel mystique' share '*the illusion of demediating mediation*' (2003: 3; emphasis in the text), the idea that certain types of experience have the power to erase the mediation of reality altogether. Travel to foreign lands is replete with demediating mediation, as it allegedly involves contact with unspoiled otherness, 'a cleansing process that renews perception' (2003: 3). Although she traces parts of her argument back to various classical anthropological and sociological studies of tourism, she concentrates mainly on the work of MacCannell (1989), who identifies in travel a search for authenticity stripped of the marketing discourse of tourism. Strain's understanding of film viewing as demediating mediation is based on the medium's power to manufacture a version of authenticity while simultaneously blocking and filtering the mechanisms of exoticization employed in the construction of cinematic imagery and narrative. Film has, in short, the power to simulate authenticity while denying that it engages in simulation (Strain 2003: 18–20). This enables the viewer to engage fully with image and narrative like a traveller who

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deludes themselves that they have reached the core of 'other' cultural realities when they have, in fact, simply hit upon the wall of yet another representation. I agree with Strain that the demediation of representation is inherent in the cinematic experience, and I maintain that it can be marketed or sought after (by virtual or actual travellers) as 'the real experience'.

Interesting though they are, these works do not have much to say about the communities or nations used in destination images and narratives. The centre of attention is the viewer, the tourist or consumer or alternatively the producer, rather than the 'consumed' host. I would like to discuss a different approach that integrates community responses to the general picture of tourist production and consumption. This comes from *Film-Induced Tourism* (2005), the only existing study of tourist development through film by Beeton. For Beeton, film-induced tourism includes 'visitation to sites where movies and TV programs have been filmed as well as to tours to production studios, including film-related theme parks' (Beeton 2005: 11). This definition is rather broad for the purposes of the present study, but does not deviate from Strain's basic argument. Beeton recognizes the roots of contemporary tourism in the eighteenth-century Romantic movement that promoted the picturesque, idealized versions of landscape for consumer gratification. Drawing on Seaton (1998), she sees the picturesque as the predecessor of the 'tourist gaze' that idealizes nature and otherness (peasantry, noble savagery) (Beeton 2005: 5–8), a point I will reiterate in some case studies of this book. According to Beeton, contemporary media representations of place share this idealization with eighteenth century literary creations and can induce the desire to visit places and cultures. To support this thesis she has recourse to MacCannell's (1989) argument that mediated versions of tourist locations generate 'markers' of places in the form of images. Film has precisely this function: it ascribes meaning to locations through imaging, making them desirable destinations.

Beeton is concerned about the impact that tourism can have on a location and its environs. 'Tourism carries with it the seeds of its own destruction' (Beeton 2005: 12) because it can lead to environmental destruction and community disintegration. Debating the problem from a destination-marketing point of view, Beeton argues for organized sustainable development strategies. Her commitment to this community development project is admirable. Although her methodology draws upon other disciplines, mainly psychology and market studies, it also incorporates Marxist sociological and anthropological approaches to tourism, largely forgotten in contemporary research that celebrates consumerism but brushes aside its pitfalls. My approach in this book differs

on one point from Beeton's: I am concerned less with the economic and more with the cultural impact of cinematic tourism (or their relationship), especially the consequences of host–guest interaction for local and national identities. But before I discuss the politics of this interaction, it is necessary to be clear about the minutiae of relations between Hollywood film and tourist industries.

The 'sign industry': from film to tourism (and back again)

The terms 'film' and 'tourist industries' take us back to the radical critique of mass consumption pioneered in the 1930s and the 1940s by a number of Frankfurt School theorists, among them Theodor Adorno (1991) and Max Horkheimer (Adorno and Horkheimer 1993). In an era of European totalitarian politics, the rise of mass media in democratic countries such as the USA was regarded as a demagogic tool that might divert collective consciousness from sociopolitical problems. Consequently popular culture – music, film, magazines – was viewed by Frankfurt School theorists as a force that could destroy the potential for a social revolution. Especially in the light of an increasing success of Hollywood musicals, Adorno and Horkheimer expressed the fear that the recipients of cinematic messages could become consumers in *abstracto* – that is, consumers who have lost their particularity and become interchangeable and quantifiable. As Kellner (1989) recently clarified, according to Adorno and Horkheimer's version of critical theory, this reification can be detected in capitalist societies in general. Quantifiability, interchangeability and abstraction may also point to what Marx described as a shift from use value (value as such, exemplified in the use of things) to the exchange value (value acquired in and through the act of exchange) in capitalist systems. This shift applies both to the consumers themselves and the products that they consume.

Compelling though this sociological model may be, it tends to underestimate the complexity of production, because it considers the manufacturers of cultural goods mere participants in a conspiracy against collective consciousness. But as Hesmondhalgh (2002: 4–6, 232) has explained, the manufacturers of cultural goods in global industries are involved in a creative manipulation of symbols to such an extent that they should be considered agents of sociocultural change. Creative manufacturers often derive non-economic satisfaction from their involvement in production processes, even though they remain dependent on basic economic planning (e.g. advertising of products) (Caves 2000: 2–4). The relationship between creative arts and commerce seems to have become

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closer as sectors within creative industries that were not commercial in the past (e.g. performing arts, broadcasting) have become commercial. For some scholars, most modern economies are consumption-based, and 'social technologies that manage consumption derive from the social and creative disciplines' (Cunningham 2005: 293). Pushing this argument further, Castells (1996) and Lash and Urry (1994) inform us that symbolic creativity permeates contemporary socioeconomic life, as more industries fashion themselves on the cultural model. This invites us to examine the social relations (see also Urry 1995: 129) of creativity, that is, the ways in which cinematic images of tourism are produced by Hollywood companies *and* exploited by tourist providers. There is an implicit interplay of artistic creation and market production that cannot be ignored, because it is central to the innovative aspects of commodification (Hartley 2005: 5–6; Miège 1987). These reflections point in one direction: production modes have their *own culture* (Zelizer 1983, 1988: 618) that needs to be understood before it is condemned.

The modes of contemporary production must correspond, or respond, to those of consumption. To coordinate the analysis of film and tourist industries we must, therefore, question exactly *what* film viewers and potential tourists consume. In films and film-induced tourist practices potential tourists never seem to consume *specific* objects, but clusters of signs: they are tempted to buy holidays to filmed spots because of their Hollywood aura; they are invited to relive the film through tours 'on location'; and they are enticed to buy souvenirs that refer to the mythical figures of the cinematic plot. Tourist production is made possible through film consumption only because film produces meaning in the first place (Ateljevic 2000: 381), but these cinematic messages do not develop in a sociocultural void: they comprise representations of existing consumer experiences that circulate in the realm of contemporary culture. It may be more correct to argue that mythical (Rojek 2000: 54; Shields 1991), socially constructed images and experiences of place and culture are not *directly* the product of tourist industries, but are over-determined by a variety of 'non-tourist practices, such as film, TV, literature, magazines' (Urry 1990: 3; see also Taylor 2001) and other consumption objects and processes. The interconnectedness of all these different phases and sectors of the culture industries confirms that tourism begins with cultural 'signification' (Culler 1988; MacCannell 1989; Urry 1990: 12; Lash and Urry 1994; Wang 2000).

This demands a re-evaluation of the analytical distinction between the film and tourist industries, as they both participate in the circulation of what Jean Baudrillard (1973) has termed symbolic 'sign values'. Debating the postmodern condition, Baudrillard observed that the relationship

between the sign and the signified has loosened so much that all textual and visual meanings became arbitrary. The absence of a stable relationship between signifier and signified leaves the sign vulnerable to what Best and Kellner have called 'manipulation in coded differences and associative chains' (1997: 99). This manipulation refers both to producers and consumers, with grave consequences relating to the destruction, deconstruction and creation of social realities. Baudrillard is very pessimistic when it comes to these consequences, arguing that since images and representations simply succeed each other in arbitrary ways, we can talk about the 'death of the real' (Baudrillard 1983: 53) and the rise of a society that lives through simulations. His theory radicalized the analysis of the impact that the mass media have on the construction of reality, and questioned the ways in which 'dominant codes' of meaning rise and fall in Western liberal societies (Baudrillard 1991; Porter 1993: 2). His approach clearly transcends the classical Marxist distinction between production and consumption (see Lash and Urry 1994: 123) on which Adorno and Horkheimer based their thesis, as the two modes become interchangeable in what I will term *global sign industries*. The term is pertinent for many reasons: first, because it does not deviate from the classical argument that we do deal with *industries* that trade in images and ideas, the intangible aspects of culture; second, these industries are *global*, because they thrive on their economic and political interconnections – a point to which I return below; finally, they are *sign* industries, because they generate, manipulate and market cultural signs. Central to the operative forces of these industries is a game of endless hermeneutics: by filmmakers (of novels on which films are based), by audiences (of films) and by holiday providers (of audiences' film readings). Even tourists engage during their holidays in the collection and appropriation of signs (Urry 1990: 12) that sometimes originate in films. Hermeneutics itself *is a mode of both consumption and production*, which constantly enriches the signifying systems of our late modern world – our contemporary cultures, in other words.

I would like to drop the singular ('industry') of the Frankfurt School approach in favour of an argument that considers the diversity of production modes: first of all, there are numerous possibilities for different cultural industries to establish strategic alliances. This book looks at perhaps one of the most pronounced cases, but invites similar research into other possible combinations. The singular is inappropriate also because a variety of cultural determinants shape the marketization of cultural products. Unfortunately, this is not always a saving grace, as powerful media conglomerates simply have more transnational power than small media firms. Hollywood and its production companies have

spread their control globally by absorbing smaller companies who had less capital to finance expensive cinematic enterprises. This is not to argue that Hollywood has not been challenged by other emerging media industries. As the case of Israeli television attests, the Americanization of the media is a knife with sharp blades for both the transmitting and receiving ends of globalization. In a compelling monograph on this issue, Liebes (2003: 190) explains that although Israel's television system has embraced American technologies, genres, advertising styles and organizational modes wholeheartedly, it has simultaneously subjected all these to domestic economic and political interests. In addition to their home viewers, Bollywood films have acquired millions of fans abroad, both from expatriate Indian communities and from Western audiences. Hong Kong cinema is also spreading its influence globally (Logan 1995), invading foreign markets that were traditionally controlled by Hollywood.

This book's case studies will not discuss these emerging rivals. The reasons for this are not solely those of scholarly coherence. Hollywood rather than Bollywood or Hong Kong cinema appears as the shadowy manipulator of some travel agencies on the web. Hollywood's involvement in the provision of tourist services is irrefutable, and as the present study draws upon film viewers who review movies, book holidays and travel online, it is important to retain it as a focus. I do not argue here that such cooperation of Hollywood and tourist agencies amounts to a merging of different industries, because their relationship is regulated by contingent interests (Beeton 2005: 9). Even within film industries power and control over the production and successful marketing of a film are subject to factors that are not always predictable. Cinema corporations are always competing to secure the emotional investment of their viewers by involving film directors and other Hollywood agents in online discussions with fans (see also Ryan 1992). These actors will proceed to plan their policy independently from emerging tourist industries, although such policies may in fact benefit the latter. Convergence of interests can be 'crafted' to secure interdependencies (Castells 1996: 151–68) that will reduce risk of failure, or manage to 'silence' critical voices from without (Garnham 1990: 160–2; Hirsch 1990). The rationale of the global sign industries model refers more to the *modus vivendi* of the cultural industries, not the way they operate in practice.

The single 'culture industry' vision is dystopian also because it does not take into account the responses that those who are addressed *in* or *by* the signs may develop. To put it succinctly, it tends to dismiss the role of consumers as what Willis (1990) has termed 'symbol creators' of an entire universe of ideas and practices. In the case of the consumption

of tourist images and ideas, it assumes that cultural 'texts' (in the form of movies, posters, internet images of tourist destinations) are prescribed from above. There is an element of truth in this argument, but when we move to reception questions we note a multiplicity of textual readings that may or may not coincide with those of the originary message creators (Abercrombie and Longhurst 1998; Golding and Murdock 2000; Dunn 2005). As Mayhne puts it 'it is one thing to assume that cinema is determined in ideological ways . . . that is, that various institutions of the cinema *do* project an ideal viewer, and another thing to assume that those projections *work*' (Mayhne 1995: 159, emphasis in the text). On most occasions it is impossible to bridge the gap between ideal and real viewers because films as 'social texts' (Turner 1999), representations and negotiations of the social world, are not uniform. Most cinematic narratives tend to incorporate contradictory and conflicting social visions, suggesting to viewers both reaction and conformism. To follow Ryan and Kellner's analysis of Hollywood production, even the most ideological films carry within their narratives 'potentially progressive undercurrents in American society by delineating . . . the salient fears, desires, and needs that make up the everyday fabric of American culture' (1990: 2).

More celebratory tones of a pluralist tradition that empowers the consumer would cover up the pitfalls of production relations and ought to be treated with as much caution as the single-industry model. It has been argued that in its extreme form the pluralist argument tends to adapt for academic purposes the free market logic of neo-liberalism: if, indeed, there are no 'core' cultural meanings, only 'signs' that can be interpreted in multiple ways, then it is easy for someone with enough power to construct a whole economic empire on an attractive collection of them (see McGuigan 1992; Gitlin 1998). The cultural studies literature around the 1990s, which found its apotheosis in Fiske's (1989) and Jenkins' (1992) analysis of the hermeneutic power that audiences possess, further obscured the question. Though admirable for its rich empirical research and theoretically original understanding of fan reception, it tended to conflate political activism with the 'hermeneutic unpredictability' (Murray 2004: 12) of television and cinematic fans. As Hill (2002) has clarified, fan cultures are inherently both anti-commercial in their pursuits and interests and commodity-oriented in their nature: one cannot join them without partaking in consumption, even if they end up contesting and challenging its restrictive modes. A distinction between fan creativity and political resistance points to a series of processes that exist independently from consumer sign-reading, and compels us to address issues of exploitation and inequality, largely abandoned in media

studies. Whereas it is important for this book to consider risk management in the global sign industries or the process of sign reading by movie fans, Internet users and tourists, a few questions loom large: who is affected by this process? Who hosts all these potential 'guests' on-location? How does the local encounter with demanding consumers, who arrive at the filmed place with certain preconceptions in their mind, develop? What happens to screened indigenous cultures during such encounters? These questions demand a serious engagement with concerns that inform studies in the sociology of globalization, developmental anthropology and moral economy.

The premises of these concerns originate in the fact that media representations do, after all, affect internal perceptions of culture. I understand culture as the malleable and porous sets of beliefs, ideas, habits and customs that define and order our everyday life (Williams 1958). Such beliefs and ideas are communicated in codified ways, through signs and symbols (Geertz 1973), and define the social order. I do not argue that cultures exist or develop in isolation from the rest of the world. This solipsistic approach, favoured by early work on tourist–host encounters (see for example MacCannell 1973; Chhabra, Healy and Sills 2003) assumes that culture is a coherent and stable system that exists *a priori*. Apocalyptic theses would have it that in the era of globalization, the collapse of national boundaries and the interpenetration of the local by the global, identities and cultures become vulnerable and fragile (Arnould and Price 1993: 304; Ritzer 1996). As the argument goes, the more media conglomerates cast their shadow globally, the more likely it becomes that the palettes of locality will be eclipsed. Other scholars, avoiding this deterministic tone and the ethical questions it raises, explain that the global dissemination of cultural images through the media and in tourist business can be viewed simply as the erasure of specificities out of their context (Tomlinson 1999). More cautiously, anthropologists and sociologists point out that global flows generate their own resistance mechanisms that protect cultures and identities (Foster 1991: 236; see also Ray 2002: 5.2, 5.4). The literature on globalization is vast, but it converges upon one issue: the future of cultural specificity.

Synthesizing from these arguments, this book constructs its own polemics, accepting that media production and distribution have always been resting at the heart of the culture and identity-making projects. More than a decade ago Anderson (1991) spoke of print-capitalism as the vehicle for ideas that gave birth to national identity, arguing that collective imaginations are regulated by universalized (mediated) messages of culture. In the dawn of the twenty-first century these images and messages are not addressed only to the 'nation', or created exclusively

by its elites. The construction of popular versions of national or ethnic cultures by the media enables localities and nation-states to 'meet the world' and escape the cage of a not always happy isolation. This 'banalization' (Billig 1995) of culture, the interaction of self-imagining and external representations, triggers processes that change the face of nations and localities in unpredictable ways (Held 2000: 1–3). To reconsider Strain (2003), nations can also be caught in a process of demediating mediation, which may convince them to accept cinematic simulations of 'their indigenous monoculture' as real. To put it bluntly, externally constructed representations of a culture can attain an objective status. Often, the use of indigenous specificity by global sign industries as a valuable commodity puts massive pressure on the hosts to perform for foreigners (Nash 1977; Williams and Shaw 1998). Subsequently, it may lead to a projection of stereotypical versions of identity and the marketization of authenticity 'by the pound' (Greenwood 1977). Cultural marketization is often welcome, because it bolsters local economies and creates the preconditions for the generation of more local jobs (Leadbeater and Oakley 2005: 301), but the beneficial or damaging results of this enterprise cannot be assessed *in abstracto*, only in relation to the structural environments in which cultures live: the position they occupy in collective imaginations outside their cradle, the nation-state that hosts them and the historical and economic relationship of this state with the globe.

This is a thorny issue indeed, given that some of the book's case studies take us to less developed corners of the world. My research spans four continents (Asia, Australasia, Europe and America) and countries (Thailand, New Zealand, Greece and Cuba). Each of them has a different socio-historical and political experience that conditions responses to outside intervention, whether this be from Hollywood, tourism capitalists, or even the state. The geographic or political marginality of these countries, their peripheral role in the world economy and their colonial pasts place them in a subsidiary position when it comes to the articulation of the national or local voices that object to developmental projects originating in the economic centres of the developed West. The nature of cultural resistance to global hegemonies is narrated in the following chapters like a Hollywood story that, nevertheless, does not always have a happy ending for its hidden local heroes. Each case study will shed light on cultural specificity and national economic conditions before unveiling the theoretical universalities of resistance. Problems of structural and infrastructural development can affect the tourist sector *and* labour conditions, as often tourism in these places is 'highjacked' by foreign travel agencies, airlines and other companies that are more ready to

respond to increasing tourist demands (de Kadt 1979; Shaw and Williams 2004: 44). Rapid tourist expansion calls for makeshift solutions that involve the growth of informal markets, support poor payment, and introduce or exacerbate community rivalries and competition (see Agarwal *et al.* 2000). Globally famous images of tourist destinations may be treated locally and nationally as sources of cultural capital, and opportunities for economic capital accumulation (Britton 1991), but they may also be exorcised as foreign demons that transgress the intimate space of the nation (Herzfeld 1997). The coexistence of positive and negative, or often ambivalent and indecisive, responses to the sign industries and their consumers deserves meticulous analysis. It is important, then, to look at this group of anonymous actors who clearly comprise a necessary component in the production/consumption cycle: the cinematic tourists themselves.

The cinematic tourist

The historical origins of tourism are usually traced back to the eighteenth-century grand tour, a succession of visits to countries such as Italy, Greece, the Ottoman Empire or even the Holy Lands. Gourgouris (1996) recognized a pedagogical impetus in the peculiar habit of upper middle class and aristocratic families of subsidizing their son's adventures in unknown places. The tour familiarized young travellers with the great civilizations of the past, such as Athens and Rome (Towner 1985), and brought them in contact with foreign customs and people (Hibbert 1969; Cohen 1996: 102). The didactic element could also operate as a performative act, communicated to future audiences through travel writing. Gourgouris' analysis is interesting, but the motivation and rituals of the grand tourists were much more diverse than he suggests. Some of these travellers were indeed young students of aristocratic parentage who wanted to broaden their intellectual horizons, or artists looking for inspiration in remote countries, but others were established diplomats on political missions that propelled them to produce lengthy accounts of their experiences and observations. Work, education and leisure were coexisting modes and motivations for travel, all equally important in the history of the grand tour. Urry (1996: 120) saw in this blending of work and leisure activities the beginning of an increasing rationalization of travel that provided the modern tourist system of leisure with a *raison d'être*.

According to Urry (1990), the visual experience of touring, 'gazing upon' other cultures and environments, is a quintessentially modern act that both celebrates and domesticates otherness. Photographing, or

even recording cultures and environments can be regarded as a way of disciplining otherness and producing authoritative knowledge about it (Foucault 1979). The production of such knowledge was encapsulated in the performative act of writing about one's experiences and communicating them to a readership at home. Travel book narratives became thus 'spatial trajectories' (de Certeau 1988b: 115) that clearly 'mapped' and arranged locations in imagined registers. This domestication of travel destinations was furthered by Thomas Cook's large-scale tours in the nineteenth century that offered the first organized type of travel for leisure rather than work (Urry 2000: 180). Even Cook operated within a Foucauldian knowledge regime of travel writing. Most of his tours survived in printed forms and became as popular as the numerous travel books of the era. Readerships were allowed to move, or choose, between imagined and corporeal modes of travel. Taking into account the limitations imposed on travel readers by class – working classes could not afford the grand tour – or gender – travel was not a socially acceptable type of leisure for women for a long time – we can see how print-capitalism gave birth to the modern virtual tourist. This tourist moves in the symbolic space of textual narrative, filters adventure through other people's travel exploits, and revels in mediated acquisition of knowledge about 'other civilizations'.

The nature of contemporary virtual tourism underlies the problematic of this study. Virtual tourism through old (travel book) and new (film, the Internet) media inculcates in the modern subject a much-needed utopian aspiration to become an actual tourist. The activity of contemporary tourism itself is 'an imaginative process which involves a certain comprehension of the world and enthuses a distinctive emotional engagement with it' (Crouch, Jackson and Thompson 2005: 1). This is already present in virtual tourism through film. As de Certeau has explained, voyages simultaneously 'create and destroy the paths they take. Or, more exactly, they take their own course, but wish to lose the landscape and the way. Mysticism operates as a process whereby the objects of meaning vanish' (De Certeau 1986: 37). The tourist imagination is always-already structured through ideal images of place that transcend, and often define, tourist destinations. If place and culture are mythical constructs (Rojek 2000) then virtual tourists themselves can assume the *situational role* of tourists. Since their identity as tourists can always be deferred, it is the promise of the journey to represented locations that enables them to enjoy the film. Their symbolic move from the world of the cinema to that of the Internet, where they can 'travel' without the constraints of time, space or money, replaces the actual mode of travelling only temporarily.

I have already pointed out that the concept of cinematic tourism encapsulates the move from film viewing to actual tourism. Using this generic term can be confusing, and further terminological elaboration needs to be introduced here. I will term the cinematic viewers who surf the web for virtual consumption of potential tourist destinations (the ethnographic material of the book) *virtual flâneurs*. My association of tourism with flânerie follows Dann's recent observation that over the decades, tourism has been likened to a number of other social phenomena such as pilgrimage, sightseeing and performance (Dann 2002: 7). More meaningful metaphors are necessary, because they facilitate reconceptualizations of such an important phenomenon. Walter Benjamin's (2002) flâneur is the person who roamed the crowded city observing at a distance, yet Benjamin also saw in the flâneur the 'soul' of the mass; for him, the crowd lives through the flâneur's creativity, words and imagination (Benjamin 2002: 420). Unlike Benjamin's type, the fast mode in which virtual flâneurs engage with the world is not regulated by mere observation at a slow pace, but by the speed of their computer. The nanoseconds of transfer from one location to another ensure a 'digital' space-time compression (Lash and Urry 1994), which enables them to stay at the heart of global developments while retaining territorial distance and anonymity (Germann Molz 2004: 171). This does not prevent virtual flâneurs from dreaming, imagining and desiring the objects that films and tourist websites market. We can liken the 'arcades' of the Internet and Hollywood to the phantasmagoria of capitalism: both commodify fantasies – in the form of a desired travel, experiential authenticity and self-accomplishment (see also Rojek 2000: 58).

The passage from film to the Internet enables virtual flâneurs to tour the world anonymously but with an all-consuming desire for actual experience. The response to cinematic viewing and Internet surfing is split: on the one hand, it promotes a touring model in which an immaterial self is subjected to a camera obscura 'eye'. This eye communicates an 'objective' truth that exists independently from the observer (Crary 1992: 33). It could be claimed that the cinematic viewer's or the Internet surfer's distant engagement with other cultures (see also Turner 1993: 154) resembles Baudrillard's (1988) driver, who enjoys the American landscape through their car screen. The vast array of images that flick through the driver's eyes construct an experience that substitutes the zapping of television channels. In the hyperreal space, other cultures and landscapes are detached from their original contexts (Eco 1987) and reinvented as objects of the tourist gaze, spectacles that can be consumed or 'disposed of in much the same way as any other consumer object' (Bennett 2005: 38). But even though there are travellers and tourists

who upon arrival at a filmed location begin to simulate life 'on the screen', it would be wrong to generalize. It is therefore paramount to examine a second potential response to cinematic viewing and Internet surfing, which reinserts into vision a material, embodied self (Crary 1992: 33–34). The embodied viewer is both a spectator and an actor who can challenge the objectivity of the camera. Virtual flâneurs are hermeneutic agents because they often precede any interpretation of the film's marketing value by local and global tourist providers (Inglis 2000). To be more precise, online viewers may be seen as participants in a new version of the 'publicsphere' (Habermas 1989) that is performed, 'staged' with the help of the new media (Thompson 1995). At the same time the commodified objects of Hollywood and the Internet (the tourist destinations) invite virtual flâneurs to depart on an inner journey that will define them as the tourists of tomorrow. Like Benjamin's ideal type, their role is to engage in 'illustrative seeing', to match cinematic images with their own understanding of them (Benjamin 2002: 419) in a game of cultural *bricolage*. The decentralized and mobile gaze that collects and collates ideas 'conducts a flânerie through an imaginary other place and time' (Friedberg 1993, 1995: 67; Williams 1995: 8), by simulating the mobility of tourism. It matches actual with virtual cosmopolitanism, knowledge and experience of otherness with simulation of this experience, turning film viewing and Internet surfing into a project of personal development (Urry 1995: 145). Lash and Urry (1994: 5–6) attribute to virtual flâneurs an increasing 'aesthetic reflexivity', the ability to monitor and evaluate rather than passively accept a predetermined place in the social world. The aesthetic reflexivity of virtual flâneurs resembles the Romantic form of the grand tour(ist) gaze that emphasized privacy, solitude and spiritual growth through an intense engagement with the observed object (Urry 1995: 137).

Even in the case of corporeal tourism, consumers cannot be treated as part of an exploitation apparatus that functions through a gaze fabricated by a culture industry, with no critical attitudes. As MacCannell (2001) has suggested, actual tourists are conscious that what they are offered is fake. Re-examining Urry's 'tourist gaze' (1990), MacCannell does not deny that tourists can be manipulated by the tourist industry for marketing purposes. It is precisely their self-recognition as *manipulated* (and not *manipulative*) subjects that makes them reconsider what travel agents offer them. This 'second gaze' enables virtual and actual tourists to enjoy their encounter with new places and cultures in ways different from those suggested by tourist markets. Unlike some film studies that see 'the shape of the media {being} determined by its audiences' culturally-shaped desires' (Hesmondhalgh 2002: 83), MacCannell

recognizes both the industries' work and the tourists' agency. Risking the accusation that I have turned into the devil's advocate, I would like to outline my main objection to MacCannell's argument. Although the second gaze is usually aware of the fabrication of 'induced' (industry-produced) images of tourist destination (as opposed to the 'organic', first-hand accounts of a place by visitors (see Daye 2005: 14)) the recognition of fabrication does not always guarantee resistance. The case studies of this book shed light on a rather disconcerting pattern of conformism that by no means applies to all viewers.

It would be incorrect to argue that corporeal travelling has been replaced by movie watching and web browsing (Dewailly 1999; Urry 2000). I would also like to avoid futuristic arguments that see virtual travel eliminating tourism, preserving ecologically important sites intact (Pinney 1994). I certainly do not side with theorists who separate the virtual from the real, and by extension overstress the playfulness of identity online (Rheingold 1994; Turkle 1995). Rather, I understand Internet technology as a socially shaped phenomenon (MacKenzie and Wajcman 1985; Webster 1995) that does not unilaterally determine social life but is inserted into existing forms of social interaction to mediate them (Williams 1974). For example, it can be argued that the Internet has the power to erase the boundaries between leisure and work that define contemporary tourism. Internet sites related to tourism or films that represent and advertise tourist destinations can be accessed at work. Undoubtedly, the very act of surfing belongs to the regime of leisure, but this simply reverses the argument that work has always been reflected in leisure activities (Rojek 1995: 4). It is more important to examine how Internet surfing operates as a threshold that leads into the world of actual tourism: exploring the web for more information on a potential destination, reading travelblogs and other web commentary by 'veteran tourists' before visiting a place, or even booking holidays online have become common practices. Over a decade ago Clifford claimed that tourism and television are key institutions in contemporary 'travelling cultures' (1992). Today we could add to these institutions the Internet as the space in which corporeal and virtual mobility cross and interact in manifold ways, providing the global sign industry with new customers.

The mobilization of online reviews as ethnographic material comes with its own ethical and practical baggage. Ethnography as a method of social research traces its origins in anthropological enquiry into other cultures, but in recent decades it has been applied in a wide range of fields, including the media. As a practice, ethnography is open to attacks from the disciples of a positivist tradition that supports the use of 'hard'

data and still clings to the myth of objectivity. Web ethnography is exposed to critique for the absence of face-to-face interaction between observer and observed and – given that web ethnographers deal with texts and images – the danger of imposing meaning on the available material (Hine 2000: 43–4). Some of these concerns fall within the ambit of a more general anthropological distrust in ethnographic research as a discursively opaque practice of cultural representation (Clifford and Marcus 1986). Indeed one of the main problems I faced in my web analysis was the lack of immediate interaction with the groups of Internet users. This physical distance is responsible for a paradox: on the one hand, it gave me the opportunity to observe web group discussions, while avoiding my demarcation as a 'stranger' in the community. As a user of the main websites I draw upon in this book, I achieved a combination of self-effacement and participant observation. On the other hand distance and anonymity valorized my status as an author, raising a number of questions regarding the finished product of my research (but see also Van Maanen 1988: 7–10).

My review pools are the two biggest and most popular online film databases, the Internet Movie Database (IMDB) and Amazon.com. IMDB is the global online market for films and television programmes, whereas Amazon.com is a virtual market that trades in a variety of media, including books, films, music and much more – an exemplary result of global sign trading. Both sites are consumption domains with their own customer review facilities. Their customer reviewing domains strategically create the preconditions for the establishment of 'active trust' (Giddens 1994) in virtual environments that are often regarded by users as unsafe when it comes to regular economic and social transactions. The reviewing process itself makes the customers feel that their opinion is valued. Review domains can also generate virtual communities of consumption (Kozinets 1999; Hill 2002) that exist more as 'a complex of ideas and sentiments' (Calhoun 1980: 107) than structured and fixed entities. These communities interact in neotribal ways (Maffesoli 1996) because their members do not comply with the social conventions of familiarity and tight solidarity; on the contrary, they favour the commonality of ephemeral interests (e.g. liking or disliking the same film or actor). Therefore virtual communities can be understood not as 'a *thing* [but] a process' (Fernback 1999: 217), as they emerge out of contingencies and mediated interaction.

Not all these developments are new. Global telecommunication systems such as the Internet may deterritorialize socialization, but they also reinforce established patterns of exchange for fans. Virtual worlds should not be located solely 'in some enclosed cyberspace: they exist in



human culture, knowledge, and values as well' (Kellogg, Carroll and Richards 1991: 430). As in the case of other fan cultures, interaction in the virtual consumption domains I use assumes a textual nature: chat and message lines, available on IMDB and Amazon.com, are the primary media of communication. Texts are often reproduced within the community and acquire a life and authority of their own. Henry Jenkins has explained that fan reading is 'a social process through which individual interpretations are shaped and reinforced with other readers . . . [expanding] the experience of the text beyond its initial consumption' (1992: 45). Some film viewers are anxious to conform to popular readings of the film (Brooker 2003: 207) and simply buttress discursive tropes on it. Others assume the voice of the critic who shapes collective opinion, and tend to produce deliberately provocative analyses to that end (Hill 2002: 41–2). As Nancy Baym (2000) has suggested, the presentation of a coherent identity online involves both manifestations of commonality through identification with others, and claims over uniqueness of opinion through dissociation with the wider community. The poetics of authorship are very complex, given that fan texts are 'polyvocal' rather than 'univocal' (Geertz 1986: 13–15). Moreover, we cannot know if the review itself is the outcome of more than one viewing of the film or an impressionistic account of the story written on a Saturday night after an evening at the cinema. Perceptions and readings of a film change over time, and are shaped by a variety of external factors – reviews by critics, magazine and newspaper articles – often unknown to the researcher. Lest I claim that I will provide an accurate picture of fandom, I will state in advance that I deal with fragments of the whole viewing and reception experience.

The absence of a coherent ethical framework for web ethnography makes Internet research a controversial enterprise, and I decided to follow some guidelines set by conventional fieldwork (Mann and Stewart 2000: 42–7). IMDB and Amazon.com review pools are publicly available for use, but for reasons of identity protection I avoid the disclosure of personal information about my reviewers. As a result all reviews are referenced and dated in the following chapters, but the names of the reviewers are missing. Given that the content of all posted reviews is intended for all web readers (see also Homan 1991), whether they be registered users of the site or not, I treat this type of material as deliberately intended for public access and consumption (Herring 1996; Cavanagh 1999). The international make-up of these reviewer communities did not allow me to complement online reviews with actual interviews (for an example see Correll 1995). Using web material can sabotage one's ability to think in terms of variables such as ethnicity, gender or sexuality. I was left with

echoes of the reviewers' identity or with the task of recovering it through hyperlinks or from hints in their reviews. Most IMDB and Amazon.com customers choose to state their country of origin, their ethnicity and cultural affiliations – valuable information for a study that looks into consumption in the more developed countries of the West, such as Britain and the USA. Although review pools always contain comments by viewers from the less developed world, the vast majority of online comments originate in Western countries. One cannot dissociate this from the fact that the Internet is still a fairly rare commodity: a very small number of the global population owns or has access to a computer (Lax 2004: 226). The reviewers of the study are amongst the most privileged individuals on our planet. It is easy to lump together all these 'Westerners' into an amorphous mass of consumers when one departs on these observations. Luckily, the vast majority of my reviewers are British or American; when they are not, I elaborate on potential ways their cultural affiliation might have affected their opinion. A recovery of the viewers' gender or sexual identity proved to be more difficult, mainly because in most texts it does not seem to play an apparent role. Because I was not in a position to infer how gender or sexual dispositions might have shaped opinions and ideas, I did not pursue a further investigation of the question.

Internet reviews were complemented with other websites, especially those maintained by holiday providers. They were not chosen randomly. I mainly drew upon those websites that either were consulted by my reviewers or established and maintained by the most important global sign industry actors – namely Hollywood and their tourist collaborators around the world. As Mitra and Cohen (1999) have suggested, web texts have an intertextual nature due to the presence of hyperlinks or other implicit links within their structure. This implies that I was not simply yet another reader of web reviews, but their *second order* author: by following my reviewers' suggestions, or by connecting their comments to ideas that originate in other websites I mapped their trajectory through my own movement in cyberspace. Most of the websites I use include imagery that refers to the film by which their business is informed. In a book that aspires to explain how visual culture structures the ideal tourist type the value of these images is more than decorative. It is also important to examine how viewers (my reviewers) relate to some of these images and their accompanied texts. All in all, my aim was to place web imagery, like film imagery, in its wider cultural context (Becker 1999) while examining whether it has an impact as such (Rose 2001: 3).

The organization of the book

As the title implies, one of the book's central concerns is the generation of global, national and local resistance to the establishment of film-induced tourist industries. The main part of the study follows this rationale, moving from the global to the national and then the local scene, with each chapter concentrating on one of these three levels and taking one film as a starting point. Within chapters I have adopted a more holistic approach that covers the main phases of the production and consumption cycle; these precede my examination of host responses to the phenomenon. I follow the politics of film production in Hollywood in order to discuss the use of place and culture as cinematic backdrops. Such images of place and culture may be referents to established holiday resorts or unknown corners of the world with the potential to become tourist destinations. Hollywood bestows these undeveloped locations with a reputation that invites their infrastructural development for tourists and other visitors. In the second stage of analysis I examine the reception of such films by international audiences – the virtual and future corporeal tourists of the filmed place. Looking at cinematic fans that produce online reviews of the films and the exploitation of these films by tourist providers, I explore the construction of ideal models of the 'tourist'.

The mobilization of filmed countries by holiday providers on the web and beyond contributes to the consolidation of local tourist industries in filmed locations, but also generates competition between local and foreign markets. In the third stage of analysis I consider the emergence and consolidation of local tourist industries and their investment on the locality's image as a cinematic attraction. I debate the competition for market primacy when the localities' potential is claimed by external, foreign actors and industries. I also provide some reflections on what is actually consumed by real tourists on location, although the corporeal experience of travel and tourism never becomes the focal point. The last phase of analysis is concerned with the reactions (local, national and global) that such developments generate. Reactions and responses to Hollywood and tourist interests lie at the heart of the globalization project that transforms identities and economies in multiple, uncontrolled and not always desirable ways. Although my aim was to excavate the formulas of local, national and global resistance to film and tourist industries, I wanted to maintain a degree of respect for the specificity of each case. I will not contend that this is an exhaustive study of film and tourism, or even of resistance to globalization; more modestly, and working through cases that developed in the first five years of the twenty-first century (1999–2004), I will offer some reflections on the nature of cinematic tourism, its politics, poetics and consequences.

In Chapter 2 I look at the construction of the tourist gaze in *The Beach* (2000) and the reception of the film in fan sites as a 'traveller's utopia'. The turning point in the politicization of this enterprise was the exploitation of Thai natural resources by Hollywood. A strategic alliance of 20th Century Fox, the Hollywood production company and the Thai authorities that wanted to promote national tourism through the film offended local, national and global environmental sensibilities. 20th Century Fox was allowed to modify the filmed location to conform to preconceived images of tropical tourist paradises despite the fact that the site was protected by national conservation laws. Independent environmental and tourist agents also played an auxiliary role to this end, promoting their own economic interests in the region and suppressing local and national criticisms. The chapter follows the organization of Thai and international ecological protests against the alleged destruction of the Maya Bay national park by 20th Century Fox, arguing that resistance to the 'sign industry' can assume global dimensions.

Chapter 3 examines the generation of a massive tourist industry in New Zealand following the global success of *The Lord of the Rings* (LOTR) cinematic trilogy (2001, 2002, 2003). Drawing on responses of reviewers and the nature of the LOTR commodification by online tourist providers, I argue that the LOTR trilogy promoted a type of tourism based on simulation of the films' mythical structures. I also investigate the shift from the commercialization of the LOTR tourist locations by individual tourist providers to state control, questioning whether the state-sponsored, 'organized', form of the LOTR capitalism indicates a New Zealand resistance to a global tourist economy or a battle over branding control. It is significant that in an effort to secure tourist monopolies, the New Zealand government had recourse to national myths and nationalist practices that bestowed the enterprise with the aura of cultural specificity.

Chapter 4 will examine the creation of a tourist industry on the Greek island of Kefalonia following the global success of the cinematic adaptation of Louis de Bernières' novel *Captain Corelli's Mandolin* (CCM). I discuss the commercialization of Greek Kefalonian and Italian history in the film, suggesting that we find its counterpart in Western practices of cultural tourism in Greece. I argue that sightseeing, display of interest in the history of Greece and Italy and in the Mediterranean 'folk' life is inextricably linked to Greece's orientalization in Western political and travel imaginations. These ideas also permeate some online reviews, consolidating the link between visual representation, tourist commodification and political orientalization. The development of the actual tourist industry on the Greek island of Kefalonia was rather disorganized and led by individual holiday providers. The chapter visits some of the

filmed locations and examines the ways in which they became reference points for cultural tourists. Following that, it explores Kefalonian reactions to Hollywood and tourist intrusion, and the ways these changed with time. The chapter shows how the economic tourist boom on Kefalonia after the film's release gave way to a progressive decline in international interest, providing some reflections on state-led and locally organized development of local tourist attractions.

Chapter 5 explores the marketing of Cuban culture in the West through *Dirty Dancing: Havana Nights* (DD2) (2004). More specifically, it discusses the exoticization of Cuba in film fan sites, suggesting that it is related to recent Western appropriations of salsa dancing as lifestyle. Taking into account the fact that DD2 was filmed mainly in Puerto Rico but used to advertise holidays to Havana, the chapter debates the construction of place and culture by Hollywood. This last case study deviates from the pattern established by the other three. In DD2 we do not deal with tourism generated by a film, but with cinematic internalization of tourist practices that are then reappropriated by tourist providers. It is important to consider this reverse process, as DD2 in particular does not hide its implication in the politics and poetics of Caribbean consumption. This case study will debate the unpredictable, risky and flexible relationship between film and tourist industries. At the same time, Western consumption modes of Cuban culture touch upon questions of imported (mobile) and appropriated lifestyles (from the Caribbean to Western countries) that enter our everyday life. This questions the theoretical argument that tourism as a practice stands apart from leisure and 'work time'.

The final chapter draws on the political, cultural and economic dimensions of cinematic tourism to debate the nature of resistance or accommodation to foreign capitalist and cultural hegemonies. I mainly examine the extent to which resistance to the global sign industries is generated from the urgency to protect cultural and natural versions of authenticity. More specifically, I maintain that a dialogical production of authenticity through forced encounters with sign industries and their consumers informs national representations but does not unilaterally define collective identities. National politics, which are aggravated by the presence of sign industries, are also involved in their articulation. Thus the book aspires to avoid the trap that Herman and McChesney's (1997) 'cultural imperialism' thesis constantly sets for students of globalization. Revisiting the argument, I argue that truly, whether they be positive or negative, the effects of globalization cannot easily be divided into economic and cultural, because the two domains of human experience interlock. At the same time, however, we need to understand *how* they

interlock – a question largely neglected in Herman and McChesney's analysis. To this end, we need to examine the moral reasoning of local and national resistances to sign industries, which is informed by local cosmologies. Underneath the cultural specificity of these responses, however, there is a universal pattern that will provide the book with a conclusion.

6 Farewell to authenticity?

Capitalist/cultural hegemony and the structure of resistance

On a sunny July day I found myself outside Slovakia's main airport waiting for a taxi that would take me to my hotel in Bratislava. A courteous taxi driver approached my travel companion and me, gave us a big smile that revealed a few missing teeth, dropped a low bow and pointed to his car. Luck, then, was with us: someone was available for the much-needed lift despite the traffic. Naturally, we smiled back and using the essential paralinguistic signs, we asked for the price. The man however, had already extended his hand to me. How civilized, I thought: here is a stranger who does not forget his manners and treats tourists like human beings. The aura of the whole performance had worked its charm on me, and smiling back I gave him a firm handshake. It was only when his fellow taxi drivers laughed and he grabbed my rucksack to put in the taxi that I realized my misreading: he only wanted to get on with work and move on to the next customer. He had certainly recognized a romantic fool in me: upon arrival at our destination, he asked for what we found out to be double the amount of money for the designated distance.

It is not so much that someone managed to play on me the trick that Kefalonian Greeks had successfully tried on capitalist intrusion following the *Corelli* boom years ago – although, to have a sociologist who studies the staging of authenticity make a fool of herself in this way admittedly bears the irony of Nemesis. It is more the case that even today, narrating this incident leaves me with the same bitter taste that I get when reading Georg Lukács' (1968) gloomy elaboration on Marxist theory: has the progress of productive processes eroded our humanity? For that Slovakian taxi driver, the art of self-presentation had acquired a 'phantom objectivity' (Lukács 1968: 83), a rationalized autonomy that detached it from its fundamental nature. The intrinsic value of friendliness did not apply to his professionalism, simply because on a hot summer day a taxi driver has no time to reflect on the 'partial consciousness' that the capitalist system cultivates.

One wonders, of course, how I came across to that Slovakian man. Given the transitory nature of our encounter, I must have been less than a Thai 'wallet on legs', a pretentious tourist who tries to be 'nice' and 'interested' in the well-being of his service facilitator. A feeling of indignation and injustice might have risen in him when I became amicable. With remorse I realize that he was not the one who had exploited his positional role in the system of tourist services. It was I, the one who had misrecognized our encounter as genuine human exchange, devoid of economic imperatives. Despite my academic reflexivity, I was replicating the attitude of the average tourist that MacCannell (1973) described in his pioneering essay on staged authenticity – worse, I was denying the existence of social inequality that defined the taxi driver's positional role and mine. One wonders if the practice of cheating could be understood as a form of resistance to the structure of the economic system in which we are situated. Another issue to consider is the convergence of my cultural and economic identity: how much did my 'English front' (to him, I must have been a stereotypical Westerner) aggravate his silent resentment?

In the opening chapter of this book I clarified that this is as much a study of the ability of sign industries to spread their power globally as it is an investigation of the responses that localities and nation-states develop to the challenge. My Slovakian incident nicely encapsulates the dilemmas and consequences of such responses: first, it highlights the inevitable pressure representational apparatuses exercise on host cultures to replicate the formalized 'stage' that these apparatuses produce for them; and second, it invites a sensitive approach to cultural specificity when we examine responses by host cultures. Early on I explained that responses to representations and simulations that originate from without is conditioned by the sociohistorical experience of nation-states and localities. This concluding essay examines the nature of these responses to the calls of economic and cultural globalization from a critical perspective. Undoubtedly, the academic search for resistances to the capitalist system is as old as Marxist theory and has been under constant attack in recent years by the defenders of pluralism (for a review see Hesmondalgh 2002: 82–5). In this conflict there lies a fundamental confusion about the correlation between culture and economics, which I will attempt to address in the following pages.

In a relatively recent study, Herman and McChesney (1997) examined the globalization of culture industries, lamenting the commercialization of communication and the subsequent homogenization of culture. In fact, their study comprises a series of examples of what in media studies came to be called 'cultural imperialism', the control and elimination of cultural identities by powerful media conglomerates. Media entertainment,

according to this thesis, weakens democratic dialogue and eventually replaces it. The result is a world colonized by uniformity and lack of critical voice, a *Matrix*-like state of affairs that works its way through our brain every time we plug ourselves in to the chosen medium. Sign industries simply accelerated and convoluted this process by directly introducing countries into the game of collective self-presentation: yesteryear's viewers of images generated in distant countries are now invited to enact them for a second-order audience of tourists; 'authentic stages' are raised in every part of the world to respond to this insatiable search for pure, unspoiled culture; and whole nations relegate their real self to forgotten history in order to embrace the capitalist value of identity-trading. According to this thesis, the domination of capital is unquestionable.

After considering the four cases that this book examines, we can only admit that there is an element of truth in the argument: the obstinate resistance of Thai localities to global capitalist interests and their internal representatives, the Thai state, did not bear any fruits. To be precise, the fruits it bore were rather sour, given that *The Beach* boycott was cleverly used by Hollywood and its capitalist satellites in subsequent publicity campaigns. Today anyone with an Internet connection can visit sites that trade in exotic Krabi holidays and book a room in the newly erected traditional style hotels of the Phi Phi islands. In spite of the international support from well-organized activist circles, the battle was fought and lost. Much like the Thai state, which from the outset acted like a partner of external economic interests, the New Zealand state seemed willing to adopt capitalist tactics so as not to be marginalized in the battle for brand monopolies. The glamourization of Auckland as a 'fashionable' urban destination for *LOTR* fans and the renaming of New Zealand as the new Middle Earth simply shows how the periphery 'beats' the centre by emulating it. The Mediterranean example does not deviate from this pattern: despite – if not because of – their initial protestations against the CCM industry, the Kefalonians accepted the commodification of their island as a way out of economic marginalization by the national centre. International tourist providers detected this lack of economic state regulation early on and stepped in to appropriate the terrain. As a result, today many Kefalonians who work in the service industry cater for foreign tourists *on behalf* of international tourist providers. So, even though the CCM sign industry did not manage to radically change the nature of Kefalonian tourism, it did take possession of the Kefalonian economy without encountering much local or state resistance. Perhaps more surprising has been the total absence of Cuban state control in the case of *DD2* but also the images and ideas it stands for in the global capitalist

scene. But as I explained in detail, *DD2* is the product of a sign industry that reinvented 'Latin America' in political and economic networks a long time ago. The absence of any Cuban resistance to the commodification of identity and place is the consequence of a firmly consolidated Americanization, but also the internationalization and subsequent decontextualization of cultural products and practices (music, dancing) related to Cuba. It is not only that the origin of cultural products matters little to consumers (as film reviews confirm), but also that their hybridization makes legitimate claims over their origins a difficult business. As a result, in the circulation of global signs Havana and San Juan become the same imagined *topos* sold out to virtual flâneurs who constantly chase after the chimera of an authentic experience. Implicit in this failure of subaltern resistance remains the role of long-established patterns of colonialism or cryptocolonialism that the four countries endured in the past, and which crept into the products of the respective sign industries.

All four cases reveal the enormous complexity (Giddens 1990; Held *et al.* 1999; Urry 2003) of late modernity and invite us to accept that the confluence and interconnectedness of changes in the economic, cultural and political domains has reached its apogee and makes the compartmentalized study of different domains of human experience very difficult. This sounds like a *de facto* explanandum. In postmodern studies of globalization this interconnectedness is even imagined as a Leviathan of consumer capitalism that promulgates unprecedented market uniformity and swallows up cultural distinctiveness only to spit out a single, global culture (Jameson 1984). Five chapters into this book the argument becomes very attractive indeed; all we need is to have recourse to the Frankfurt School logic of cultural 'standardization' (Held 1980: 70–6) to put a full stop to the analysis.

I will not distance myself from this thesis altogether. For anyone who believes in social justice and equality, the economic methods of sign industries outlined in the previous chapters are too gross to ignore. To re-member the Slovakian incident, their ultimate victims are not the consumers of half a dozen movies or package holidays, but the ordinary people of the filmed and touristified localities who have to earn their living in the new order. Of course we need to note that the damage was not present in all four cases: a strong response from the New Zealand state bears the potential to regenerate communities, as has been noted in a recent study (Beeton 2005). More often than not, however, forced touristification hardens preexisting ethnic, class and gender structures of inequality, as the cases of Thailand, Greece and Cuba indicate. In other words, sign industries often act as catalysts in national or international politics to sanction unsound political orders. But behind the sociological

rhetoric of economic 'incorporation' and subsequent loss of cultural uniqueness for those subjected to the demands of sign industries, there lies a slightly modified *problématique*. Its focal point is the *cultural* encounters of localities and states with the representatives of sign industries and their role as vehicles of sociocultural change.

Lest I am accused of confusing the social (the acclaimed terrain of sociology) with the cultural, I will explain that my combination of the two is based on correlation rather than identification. As anthropologists have explained, 'the shift from a social to a cultural idiom . . . is largely the outcome of the emergence of European nationalism' (Herzfeld 1992: 68). The cases of cinematic tourism explored in this book suggest that what happens locally constitutes a response to, or reflection of, hegemonic national discourses of identity and culture (see also Just 1989). I use the term 'hegemony' in a post-Gramscian sense (Laclau and Mouffe 1995) to describe the construction of self-understandings through an almost imperceptible but unrelenting channelling of ideas from the powerful political centres of the West to the peripheral countries that have fallen prey to the cinematic tourist gaze. Since the trajectories of cultural hegemonization that I explored are linked to early modern colonialisms, I will not pretend to be wholly indifferent to the cultural imperialism thesis. My constant movement from the local/regional to the national and international scene (and back again) was an attempt to provide a holistic account of resistances to globalization and its histories at the receiving end. But the shift from the social to the cultural also 'occurs through the generalization of what, at the local level, are relatively intimate distinctions between outsiders and "our own"' (Herzfeld 1992: 99). In our case, the designated outsiders can be either the representatives of global economic centres (Hollywood crews and production companies, tourist agencies) or, by cultural affiliation, the tourists.

The explored local and national responses were directed at both: in Thailand, localities became involved in the international boycott of *The Beach* and the commodification of Phi Phi Leh, but also mediated their opposition to Western tourist practices through language, often accompanied by action. The New Zealand state marshalled elements of nationalist practices to respond to foreign capitalist interference. The Kefalonians attempted to obstruct Hollywood production and still deny foreign tourists the right to enter the private domain of culture by serving them CCM's staged authenticity. Even in products of the tourist gaze that signify Cubanness/Caribbeanness, such as popular music, the logic of resistance to Western tourist invasion persists. The four cases are obviously different in focus and background, but even across responses as variable as these interesting patterns can emerge. The pattern that

marks these four cases is the recurring use of discursive practices analogous or identical to nationalist ideology. Modifying the original Foucauldian term, I use 'discourse' to refer to language constitutive of *praxis*, the conscious reworking of the subaltern's experience into a meaningful whole (Lukács 1968). Such discursive practices enable large groups that are caught in the mechanics of master–slave relationships to resist power while simultaneously asserting their solidarity and cohesion. In the face of encounters characterized by inequality, the 'imagined communities' (expatriate groups, localities and nation-states) of this study needed a protective shield to preserve themselves from what they recognized as the road to 'incorporation' by global sign industries.

What is *actually* protected from 'corruption' is a different question. As a number of theorists have consented, cultures – especially cultures that experienced direct or symbolic colonization at some point in their life course – should be viewed as relational products. I will limit my references to nationalism and colonialism studies, as they better relate to the subject matter of the book. Commenting on the production of mechanical solidarity, Anderson points out that the conditions of collective self-narration are potentially intersubjective, because 'through language the nation presents itself as simultaneously open and closed' (Anderson 1991). Partha Chatterjee (1986) may be critiquing Anderson for his Eurocentric model of nationalism, but he also supports the idea that formerly colonized nations develop a dialogue with colonial powers. The domain of anti-colonial nationalism becomes that of culture (what he calls the 'spiritual'), to which the colonizer is denied access (Chatterjee 1993: 3–5). A number of other writers before and after Chatterjee have developed the same take on post-colonial nationalism: as opposed to the 'material' world of colonial rule (the political and economic terrain), 'culture' should be viewed as the private sphere of the nation (Fanon 1967, 1970; Bhabha 1990, 1994; Gilroy 1987; Herzfeld 1997). Undoubtedly, any 'imagined community' and its members wish to forget that their commitment to a nationalist ideal is the product of colonial violence. However, before imagining oneself, someone else imagined one; selfhood is the synthetic product of conflict between the desire for a uniform, independent self and external representations. To transfer these reflections back to tourist studies: culture and authenticity should be viewed as the outcome of interactions between hosts and guests, 'in which tourees attempt to mirror tourists' desires and vice versa' (Cohen 1988a; Ryan 1991; Kroshus Medina 2003: 355). Discursive practices of staged authenticity in tourist encounters are based on patterns of incorrigible misrecognition: of one's own identity as pure and free of alien intervention; of host identities as pure and untouched by visiting 'others' – whether these be global

televised simulacra of identity or projected tourist desires for demediating mediation 'on location'.

Here the analysis begins to provide useful insights into the reasoning, rather than the structure, of misrecognition. From the outset (the production and release of tourism-inspiring movies) cinematic tourist encounters are destined to facilitate exchange – put simply and through a rather unwelcome pun, to secure value for money. In Bourdieu's terms (1984), cinematic tourism makes possible the exchange of different forms of symbolic capital: money that tourists bring into the host country with what is locally and nationally *valued* most, culture and identity. Because Bourdieu circumnavigated the politics of social inequality that his Marxist muse (Marx 1973: 256) aspired to expose over a century ago (for a critique see Sayer [1999]), I have to stress again that in the context of cinematic tourism *capital* is forcefully equated with cultural *values*. This equation is not to be dismissed, as the signifying potential of economic practices can be both cultural and material (Ray and Sayer 1999). It is precisely this conflation of one thing for another that will provide us with the social reasoning of resistance.

We may begin by acknowledging that Thailand, New Zealand, Greece and Cuba are somehow tied to political discourses that place them in the developing world. So much is obvious from the background analysis provided in the respective chapters. All four countries have industrialized economies and operate within global capitalist structures, albeit at the margins. Yet in spite of their urgency to catch up with the economic pace of the centre, the resistance they display to its representatives assumes the form of an angry frustration for their cultural misrecognition. Implicitly or not, all four localities and states accuse the agents of cinematic tourism of one form of exploitation or another: local Thais call tourists 'white bird shit' because of their inability to recognize the value of host services; the New Zealand state's struggle to secure the monopoly of the *LOTR* was firmly based on the conviction that the *LOTR* simulation of New Zealand belonged to New Zealanders after all. The Kefalonians expressed their anger against the Hollywood agents and subsequent tourists with monetary extortion and a staging of their 'culture'. The rhetoric of cheating as resistance to foreign appropriation also dictates the content of 'Cuban' products of *DD2*'s sign industry that record actual tourist encounters. In all four cases there is a wilful expression of the belief that foreigners who enter the country to make it 'theirs' deserve neither humane treatment *nor* consideration as clever entrepreneurs. All responses exhibit the same ambivalence: they reiterate *and* contest the conventions of capitalist exchange which licenses free competition regardless of the distribution of power in the social field. This is so because cheating in any form (from

demanding payment of exorbitant amounts of money for tourist services and hustling, to claiming trade monopoly on emotional grounds) bypasses these market conventions and subverts power.

In a fashion similar to critical theory's renunciation of the emergent culture industry, Karl Polanyi (1944) has claimed that the industrialization of economy posed a threat to culture, as it led to the prioritization of the material conditions of sociality and contributed to the emergence of a market society. We note that in the system of host-guest exchange the practice of cheating representatives of sign industries challenges norms of social conduct (see also Jessop 2000) that are considered to be 'unfair' (Sayer 2000). This is hardly surprising, as the practice of cheating articulates the conviction that the host is morally allowed to take by any means what is expected in any reciprocal relationship, but what is not delivered in this instance: gratitude for the provision of good services. The basic function of hospitality is the recognition that hosts and guests share the same moral universe or 'the construction of a moral universe to which both host and guest agree to belong' (Lashley and Morrison 2000: 6). When one side in the reciprocal system is placed in the position of the subordinate, like our four countries are, the norm of reciprocity is challenged (see Gouldner 1960; Bell 1991). Not only are the hosts constrained by their duty to offer plenty in emotional and physical labour without – at least explicitly – asking anything back, but they are also not sufficiently recognized for who they think they were before touristification.

It could be argued that cheating returns the hosts to the Hobbesian state of nature, where they legitimate their demand to be reciprocated on the basis of self-interest (Berking 1999: 124). Two comments are in order here: the struggle for recognition does not take place 'at the level of appearances' (O'Neill 1999: 80) and self-regard 'is very difficult to sustain without external confirmation' (Offer 1997: 452). I will refuse to regard the calculative nature of exchange as somehow different or opposed to the spirit of pure reciprocity (Malinowski 1922; for an update see Cheal 1988). As anthropologists and sociologists have shown, in many societies the monetary calculation that openly characterizes formalized exchange finds its informal expression in the cultivation of moral indebtedness (Firth 1983: 102–3; Strathern 1983). A number of scholars from different disciplines have challenged analytical differentiations of societies on the basis of solidarity versus calculation (see Baudrillard 1973, 1975; Sahlins 1974, 1976; Douglas and Isherwood 1979; Sayer 2001, 2003) – differentiations that, as Appadurai (1986: 11) has diligently explained, derive from theoretical attempts to divorce Marxist and Maussian approaches to exchange and reciprocity. To be more precise, at stake for our four host

countries is the gesture of recognition as autonomous agents in the global scene and in cultural terms – a recognition that can never be fully expressed by tourists, the faceless representatives of media conglomerates or the various managers of tourist agencies who are tied to the sign orders that they produce and maintain (Barth 1981: 40). An *exactly* balanced exchange of economic and cultural capital is never feasible, as the two forms of capital are not identical (Sahlins 1974: 193; Ardener 1989) and the exchange does not satisfy both parties. And there is more: in the context of such imbalanced relationships as the ones I have explored, the possibility of an alternative partner would naturally alter the situation. As Bell has pointed out (1991: 254) 'two-party relationships can be understood only by reference to the large number of non-activated relations that are feasible within that social context'. Unfortunately, here there is no alternative at all, as all optional partners operate within the same system of capitalist values. The absence of any alternatives however can be detrimental for the weak: preferences in reciprocal partnerships are overdetermined by 'social definitions of value vis-à-vis material and non-material resources, as well as on socially derived representations of self' (Bell 1991: 235). As a result, guest countries are left with nothing more than the symbolic capital (the 'island of *Corelli*', the 'home of Middle Earth') that has been allocated to them from without, stranded between submission to the calls of global capitalism and the need to salvage what they can from an identity in the process of transformation.

This is a sad conclusion to draw in the midst of decades-long attacks on social rights. The patterns of globalization progressively associated with the global telecommunications scene favour a particular type of global citizenship that 'benefit[s] mobile capital, manifested in the rights of the "corporate person"' (Calabrese 2005: 301). The rights of these groups that provide the essential labour for transnational sign industries to spread their control are as marginal as ever for corporate capital and even global consumers. Undoubtedly global communications have figured, and will figure again, as the instruments of both capitalism and global justice movements, but the negligence displayed on the human and social rights front may help us understand the rational grounds of the moral outrage that anonymous people from eponymous cinematic corners of the world express every time a new sign industry is in its birth throes. Hopefully, in the process of understanding this anger, the present study has managed to crack open a door to academic research that will address the issue in its specificity. More able scholars are now invited to open the door wide.